

Struggle for change in a Nubian community

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In Kanuba the traditional pattern of marriage has begun to change. The young men and some young women, too, now hold the view, which is gaining ground in Cairo, that people should have freedom of choice in their selection of mates. At the time of our study, one marriage in Kanuba fulfilled the ideal conditions, and another young couple stood in this traditionally enviable relationship. In the second case, however, the young man resisted the pressures of both his family and the village and eventually married a girl of his own choice (who was still a cousin on one side). Among those who are attempting to change many of the traditional patterns toward patterns more in keeping with an urban model, this was regarded as a triumph for modernity.

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In another instance, a man who had been given a list prepared by his mother of some twenty related girls from among whom to select a bride had chosen from the list a girl his mother had not favored. He viewed his selection as an act of free choice, and it is true that such behavior is quite a change from that of the past, when choice was much more rigidly determined by parents and when potential mates were required to avoid even seeing each other before marriage. Nevertheless, the extent to which [56Cross-Reference: \(TABLE 5 was originally published in this location\)](#), the ideal model persists in Kanuba is surprising. According to our observation and inquiries, the data obtained are not only typical of Kanuba but are fairly representative of Nubians as a whole.

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